interfaith harmony. And they must stand against impunity for provocations and violence'.[65]

The 969 Movement

One important group of Buddhist monks is the 969 Movement. This movement grew out of the 1988 revolt and is still currently involved in campaigns against those it deems insufficiently Burmese.[66] Their fundamental ideological principle is a form of exaggerated paranoia that it is not enough that Buddhism be protected by a state that is Buddhist, for the existence of other religions within that state is a permanent threat to Buddhism's continued existence. In consequence, the 969 Movement has attacked confessional Muslims regardless of their ethnicity across Myanmar in pursuit of its goals of a religiously pure state.

One of their important leaders, Ashin U Wirathu, has been called 'Buddhism's Bin Laden'[67] due to the extremism of his views. His defenders sometimes claim this label is applied only due to media lies, as 'the media are all owned by Muslims, and they paint only negative pictures of him'.[68] However, his publicly available speeches and YouTube channels leave little doubt as to his true views[69] and his open incitement of violence. Although U Wirathu is often presented as the leader of the 969 Movement, it is probably more accurate to characterise him as leading a particularly influential faction within a movement that has multiple centres of power all drawing on traditions from within Theravada Buddhism.[70]

While it has had a great deal of influence over the developments in Myanmar's politics since 2008, the 969 Movement is pressing for even more illiberal laws and repression of the non-Buddhist population. They are intent on preventing either the NLD or the USDP moving to a more humane policy and they have recently started to denounce the NLD as being insufficiently anti-Muslim and no longer protecting the Buddhist/Burman purity of Myanmar.[71]

The 969 Movement, in its extremism, has moved significantly beyond what can be seen as orthodox Buddhist norms. In fact, it is prepared to acknowledge this and glory in the paradox. Thus U Wirathu blames Muslim shopkeepers for inspiring him to call on his followers to boycott their shops, as such actions 'are not discrimination' but done to 'protect our people's